more heavily on madaris and mosque-based networks for recruiting.[80] Instead, most of Lashkar's recruits were educated at regular—or what are called 'government'—schools.[81] A sociological profile of 100 Lashkar martyrs found their background was similar to that of low-ranking officers in the army. Most came from lower middle class families and many of them were more educated than the average Pakistani, as well as than recruits to other militant groups, having completed at least secondary education and in some cases attended university.[82] According to its own records, as of 2001 the majority of its martyrs came from Punjab with the NWFP contributing the second highest number.[83] Over time Lashkar took advantage of the growing influence of Salafism among families in rural Sindh and Balochistan, as well as its own growing organizational reach, to begin attracting recruits from those provinces as well.[84]

Through its missionary activities Lashkar expanded the Ahl-e-Hadith pool from which recruits could be drawn and recruited some of those who attended its mosques. But the group sought to win over young men from among other sects too. When recruiting from government schools and universities Lashkar often sought to inveigle Barelvis and Deobandis rather than focusing exclusively on the Ahl-e-Hadith. In addition to casting its net wider, this was also a means of missionary work since Lashkar converted anyone who joined to its interpretation of Ahl-e-Hadith Islam. Amir Rana, a researcher who has studied jihadi recruitment in Pakistan, told the author that some Lashkar recruits whom he met were unsure of their sectarian affiliation at the time they joined, and only realized after beginning the religious indoctrination regimen that they were not adherents to Ahl-e-Hadith Islam. When this happened, some chose to stay while others left for a group representing their own school of thought.[85]

Lashkar was able to overcome its sectarian disadvantage in part because recruits were drawn to militant outfits 'mostly due to dynamics in the Indo-Pakistan security competition.'[86] As already illustrated, all Pakistanis are exposed from a young age to intense propaganda about Kashmir. This meant that for some would-be militants, a group's reputation vis-à-vis the Kashmir jihad was a major reason for joining. Lashkar's propaganda about its Kashmiri exploits, its growing prowess there and support from the ISI enabled the group to draw from beyond the Ahl-e-Hadith ranks. High